

A pledge on housing, far short of fulfilled

Boston-area leaders are less than halfway to goal of new units

By Andrew Brinker

GLOBE STAFF

In October 2018, 15 top officials from cities and towns across Greater Boston gathered in front of a construction site in Somerville to make a pledge: Over the next 15 years, their communities would take the lead in digging the region out of its stifling housing shortage.

Between them, they pledged, they would build 185,000 homes by 2030, a lofty but necessary target.

There are “1.5 million residents rep-

resented here that deserve housing stability,” said Joe Curtatone, then the mayor of Somerville.

But 2030 is just four years away now. And the communities are nowhere close.

Despite growing political momentum to address the region’s housing crisis and efforts to make it easier to build, the 15 cities and towns of the Metro Mayors Coalition — including Boston and many of its near neighbors — had only permitted around 76,600 new homes through 2024, according to recent data from the Metropolitan Area Planning Council. That’s just 60 percent of what was supposed to be in the works by now.

“There’s no way of looking at this

HOUSING, Page A11

‘The way we pay for health care in the country creates a game.’

DONALD BERWICK, former head of Centers for Medicare and Medicaid Services

Sepsis cases soaring. Or, is it just the billing for them?

Increase spotlights clash between insurers and providers over more severe diagnoses

By Jessica Bartlett

GLOBE STAFF

It can come seemingly out of nowhere: a patient gets an infection — in the lungs, bladder, or pretty much anywhere — and the body’s immune system overreacts, sometimes so severely the patient ultimately dies.

The condition is called septicemia, or sometimes referred to as sepsis or

septic shock. And by the numbers, Massachusetts has seen an alarming increase in cases.

Or has it?

The number of hospitalizations Massachusetts has seen for septicemia has more than tripled since 2010, to more than 42,000 people in the year ending September 2025, preliminary state data show. Since at least 2019, it

has been the third-leading cause of hospitalizations in Massachusetts.

Some of the uptick may be better recognition and diagnosing. But experts, insurers, and even some providers point to another explanation that is less about the actual medical threat and more a statement on modern health care: the increasingly sophisticated battle between hospitals and insurers over billing, each side using the power of artificial intelligence and other tech tools to protect their

SEPSIS, Page A10



\$9 billion in energy savings seems like a bright idea. But is it real?

By Kelly Garrity
GLOBE STAFF

Under pressure for months over skyrocketing heating and electricity charges, Massachusetts House lawmakers last month took steps to check some of the nation’s highest utility bills.

And they’re not modest about the result: a whopping \$9 billion in potential savings for ratepayers over the next decade, they claim, with immediate savings on the way.

Don’t cash that check just yet. A number of critics of the legislation say the claimed savings are illusory, and even a key Beacon Hill leader has vacillated over

whether ratepayers would see much benefit right away.

After the Massachusetts House passed its version of an energy bill in February, House Speaker Ron Mariano acknowledged in a television interview that, if enacted, the changes are “not going to help much at all” in the short term.

This, despite the previous claim of Democratic leaders the legislation would provide an “immediate” \$1 billion in savings by slashing a number of charges on monthly energy bills that fund the state’s primary energy efficiency program. One expert said

A \$1 billion cut to efficiency programs, for example, may reduce electric bills by a few bucks a month.

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Robert Mueller has died. The former longtime head of the FBI and investi-

gator into the Trump campaign’s alleged links to Russia was 81. **C20.**

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Land of the unclaimed

Tips on securing your bags and preventing your treasures — including the occasional Hoggle — from ending up in luggage purgatory. **Travel, N11.**



Election officials balk at voting changes from GOP

By Sam Brodey

GLOBE STAFF

WASHINGTON — President Trump and his Republican allies in Congress are increasingly intent on a massive overhaul of the country’s elections in time for the 2026 midterms.

But an important group of people are warning that’s not possible: the professionals who actually run those elections.

Around the country, state and local election administrators have been warily eyeing the proposed

changes contained in the Save America Act, as Republicans escalate their effort to pass it.

Among its sweeping proposals: mandating voters prove their citizenship in person to register to vote and also show a photo ID to vote at the polls; and ending mail-in ballots for nearly all voters. Combined, those measures could block millions of eligible voters from the polls, according to analysis from voting rights advocates.

Complying with the changes, and

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